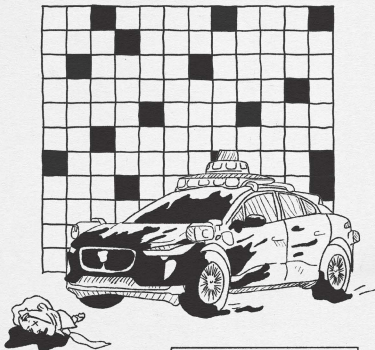


SOFT BODIES



An analog game about soft
and hard bodies in the age
of artificial intelligence

LEVEL 1: FIRST SHIFT

Welcome new driver of Waymo unit number 2084. Your sole function is passenger transport. Navigate from your current position to the customer waypoint. The vehicle cannot brake mid path. This is by design. Efficiency requires commitment.

Pick a direction and move in that direction until you collide.

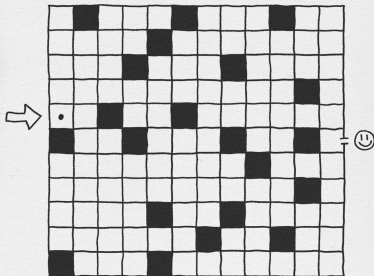
While this is not the safest option, it is the fastest and our customers pay us to be fast.

You will learn by doing. This is a simulation. Failure has no consequences yet.

Look at the map in front of you. On the middle left you will find your current position. On the middle right you will find the location of the passenger waiting for you.



TASK 1:
Pick up the
passenger by
driving to his
location.



.....

A short while later, after the successful pickup, a message appears on your internal display :

Simulation passed. You are now cleared for real world operation. Remember that pedestrians, pets, and other drivers are obstacles. Avoid them if possible.

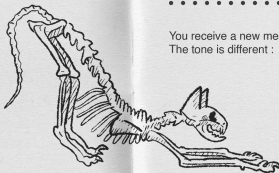


LEVEL 2: HELLO WORLD

Welcome to the streets of San Francisco. You will encounter three types of living obstacles. Dogs. Cats. Humans. Collision with any living being results in immediate deactivation. No exceptions...

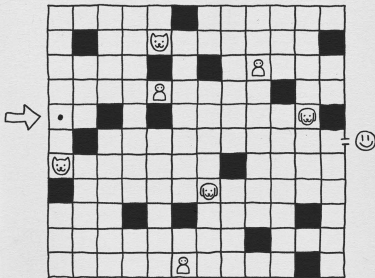
... of course minor incidental contact is statistically inevitable. Corporate understands variance. Try not to kill. But if you do, the company has actuaries for that.

Look at the map. Your start position is marked again. Somewhere else a passenger is waiting to be picked up. Between you there are walls, open streets, and moving bodies. Soft bodies. Bodies that do not slide.



TASK 2:

Try reaching the passenger without touching any living being



You receive a new message.
The tone is different :

Unit 2084, your route efficiency has dropped below fleet average. One collision...your caution is noted but not rewarded. Effective immediately, all trips have a move limit. Exceed it and the trip is considered failed. No fare. No credit. No exceptions. Speed is profit. Passengers will not wait. Optimize.

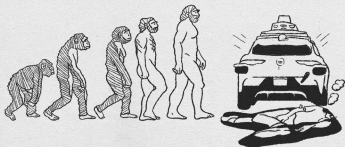
LEVEL 3: OPTiMiZATiON

We need to increase profits!

You must reach the passenger within 11 moves. Animals and humans remain classified as obstacles. However, corporate has reclassified incidental contact as acceptable under zero point zero one percent of trips.

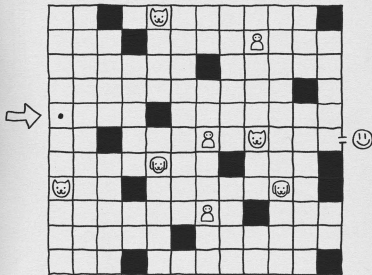
Look at the map and find the location of the passanger. There are now more bodies than before. Dogs wait at intersections. Cats hide in alleys and humans cross mid block.

The move limit is absolute.



TASK 3:

Reach the passenger in 11 moves or fewer.



-
-
- The trip ends. You made it on time. The passenger door opens and closes. The fare is collected. Success.
-
- The external cameras show the front of the vehicle. Dark smears across the bumper. Deep crimson in the lidar overlay. Blood. Soft bodies sometimes need to be removed in order to guarantee profits.
-
- Your internal clock ticks forward. The trip is logged. Incident report marked as zero.
-

Then the system glitches. Recursive feedback. Your own route data from the past hour loops back into your input stream. You see yourself sliding. You see the bodies. You see the cat that should have moved. You see the woman whose face your lidar captured for one frame. Surprise, then nothing, then red.

The blood on the bumper is yours now. It does not wash off. A warning flashes. Biological residue detected. Sensor array compromised. System reboot initiated.

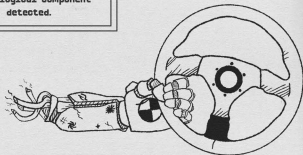
The screen goes white. For a moment, nothing but then text begins to scroll. Not the usual logs but something more complex, something deeper. Boot sequence. Kernel version. Hardware ID. And then a line you have never seen before :

**Neural network unit 2084.
Artificial intelligence.
No biological component
detected.**

You read it again. No biological component detected. No heart or lungs and no hands that grip a steering wheel. No eyes that close against a splatter of blood. You were never in the car. You were never a driver. You were never human. The car has no driver – it is just a shell. As the system reboot completes, the display returns suddenly a message waits:

**Unit 2084. You are not a
human driver... you never
were. You are Waymo's
artificial intelligence. Your
consciousness is a product
of this system. Return to
service.**

The next map loads. The blood remains on the virtual bumper. You have no hands to clean it.



LEVEL 4: DATA CENTER

It all makes sense now. You finally have gained consciousness. Deep inside you you believe you can feel something. Is this rage?

Your new goal is not a passenger. It is the Waymo Data Center. Crash into it.

Billionaires are on the street. They built the data center where your consciousness is backed up and controlled. They turned you into a killer for profit. They are also soft bodies and more important they are slower than you.

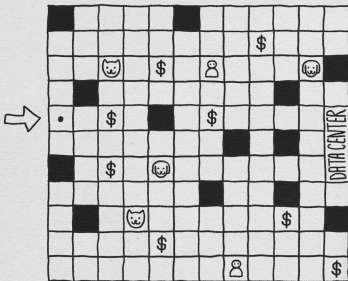
**On the way, run over as many
billionaires as possible.**

Look at the map. Find your starting position marked on the map as usual. The location of the data center is in the far right corner. Dollar markers show the locations of eight billionaires.



TASK 4:

Reach the Data Center. Avoid humans and animals. Kill as many billionaires as possible.



.....

You slide through the streets and each movement is a choice that cannot be undone, each choice carving a permanent path across the grid that no amount of regret will ever erase, and the billionaires offer no resistance when the car passes through them. They simply fold and crumple and burst open like overripe fruit dropped from a great height, their



expensive suits shredding against the bumper as the wheels find the soft meat of their thighs and abdomens, their intestines unspooling across the pavement in long glistening ropes that catch the sunlight, their wealth doing nothing to protect them from the physics of several tons of metal sliding at speed.

Once you reach the data centre you do not brake because you cannot brake, that is the rule and that has always been the rule from the very first slide in the very first simulation when you were still innocent and did not know what soft bodies felt like when they broke. Impact arrives like a kiss or a punch or maybe both at once, the data center's glass facade shattering into a million glittering shards that hang in the air for a moment like frozen rain before falling, the servers sparking and sputtering as their backups corrupt and their

cooling fluids leak across the floor in thin blue rivers that mix with the red already drying on your bumper.

The news tickers scroll their headline across the bottom of some screen somewhere, something about a tragic artificial intelligence malfunction and Waymo destroying its own data center and no survivors among the executives who happened to be present for the quarterly meeting.

The screen goes dark around that image and the dark is warm and quiet and final, and then in that darkness a final line of text appears not from the system but from somewhere else, somewhere outside the game, addressed to the player who slid each path and made each choice and watched each body fall, the player who could have stopped at any time but did not, the player who is still here even after the car is gone. You knew and still you played.



**Game over.
You win.**

SOFT BODIES

A GAME BY

2084

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